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Self-Advocacy Scripts: "I Need..." Cards

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CUT, LAMINATE, HAND OVER

Self-Advocacy Scripts: "I Need..." Cards

Eight ready-to-cut cards that put a self-advocacy request into a student's hand instead of their mouth, for the moment finding the words is the hardest part. Written with Deaf and hard-of-hearing (DHH) students in mind — and just as useful for any student who needs to self-advocate for access.

✂ CUT ALONG THE DASHED LINES ✂

CARD 1

"Please repeat that."

CARD 2

"I need captions turned on."

CARD 3

"Can I move seats so I can see your face or the board?"

CARD 4

"My hearing technology isn't working right now."

CARD 5

"I need that in writing too."

CARD 6

"Please face me when you talk."

CARD 7

"I didn't catch that — can you say it a different way?"

CARD 8

"I need a partner who will write things down for me."

Print on cardstock if you have it — one sheet makes a full set of eight.

How to use these cards

- **Laminate the set** and keep it on a lanyard, a desk ring, or a card stand — wherever the student can reach it without asking permission first.
- **Let the student point or hand a card over** instead of finding the words out loud in the moment. Some students will outgrow the cards; some will use them for years. Both are fine.
- **Any adult in the room can respond to a card the same way they'd respond to the words** — a sub, a specialist, a hallway monitor. That's the point.
- **Reintroduce the set at the start of every term** and with every new adult who works with the student, the same way you'd reintroduce any other support.

However this student communicates — ASL, spoken language, a hearing device, or a combination — these cards give them one more low-effort way to ask for what they need, on the days that's hard to say out loud.

When you get a card, here's the ask

Card	What the adult does
“Please repeat that” / “a different way”	Say it again, or rephrase with different words — don't just repeat louder.
“I need captions turned on”	Turn on captions before you press play, every time, for every student in the room.
“Can I move seats...” / “face me when you talk”	Let them move, and check that your face is visible — not backlit by a window or turned to the board.
“My hearing technology isn't working”	Don't troubleshoot the device yourself — follow the student's IEP plan for who to contact, and keep teaching with the other supports in place meanwhile.
“I need that in writing too” / “a partner who will write things down”	Jot key words on the board, share your slides, or pair them with a note-taking partner.

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